DREAMCATCHER

A science fiction story

Prologue

The sound of a burning hearth was the first thing Ludwig heard. It was humming quietly and sometimes making a loud cracking noise, as if the flames were sharp teeth biting through the logs, chewing them with vigor and satisfaction. It made Ludwig hungry, as he sat in an old leather armchair curled under a blanket.

It was a cold winter night in Norway, the winds howling outside the house walls, and Ludwig knew that the trip to the cold kitchen to get some food would drain all the warmth and happiness out of him. Thankfully, he did not have to make it, as he suddenly found he was already holding a tuna sandwich in his right hand. It is a very good feeling indeed, to recognize a hard problem and then watch it unravel all by itself. Sadly, though, Ludwig's time in this world was nearly running out, and there was an alarm at the back of his mind ringing louder and ever louder. And he knew that he would soon wake up and leave the house and struggle against the frosty winds on his way to school. It was unfair, terribly unfair, that circumstances should have aligned so perfectly, only for Ludwig to be drawn out of this dream and into mundane reality, where nothing was ever perfect. Just before fading away, the remains of Ludwig's consciousness were filled with anger and defiance, and he willed only for one thing—to keep the sandwich, the gift of this merciful world.

But it was too late. Sharply Ludwig opened his eyes and sat up in his bed, all sleepiness drained out of him. The memories from the dream were still clear in his mind, but now they seemed fake and impossible. Ludwig's house had neither a hearth, nor any leather chairs. Feeling slightly disappointed, Ludwig reached out with his right hand to silence the alarm that kept ringing, but—oh wonder!—his hand was holding a tuna sandwich, just as luscious as he'd remembered it. He turned it over and saw that it was just a regular sandwich, yet somehow it felt both alien and familiar at the same time. Ludwig could have pondered the reasons and consequences of what had just happened, but instead he did what any prudent 9-year-old would do—he quickly ate the sandwich and started packing his bag for school.

Chapter 1